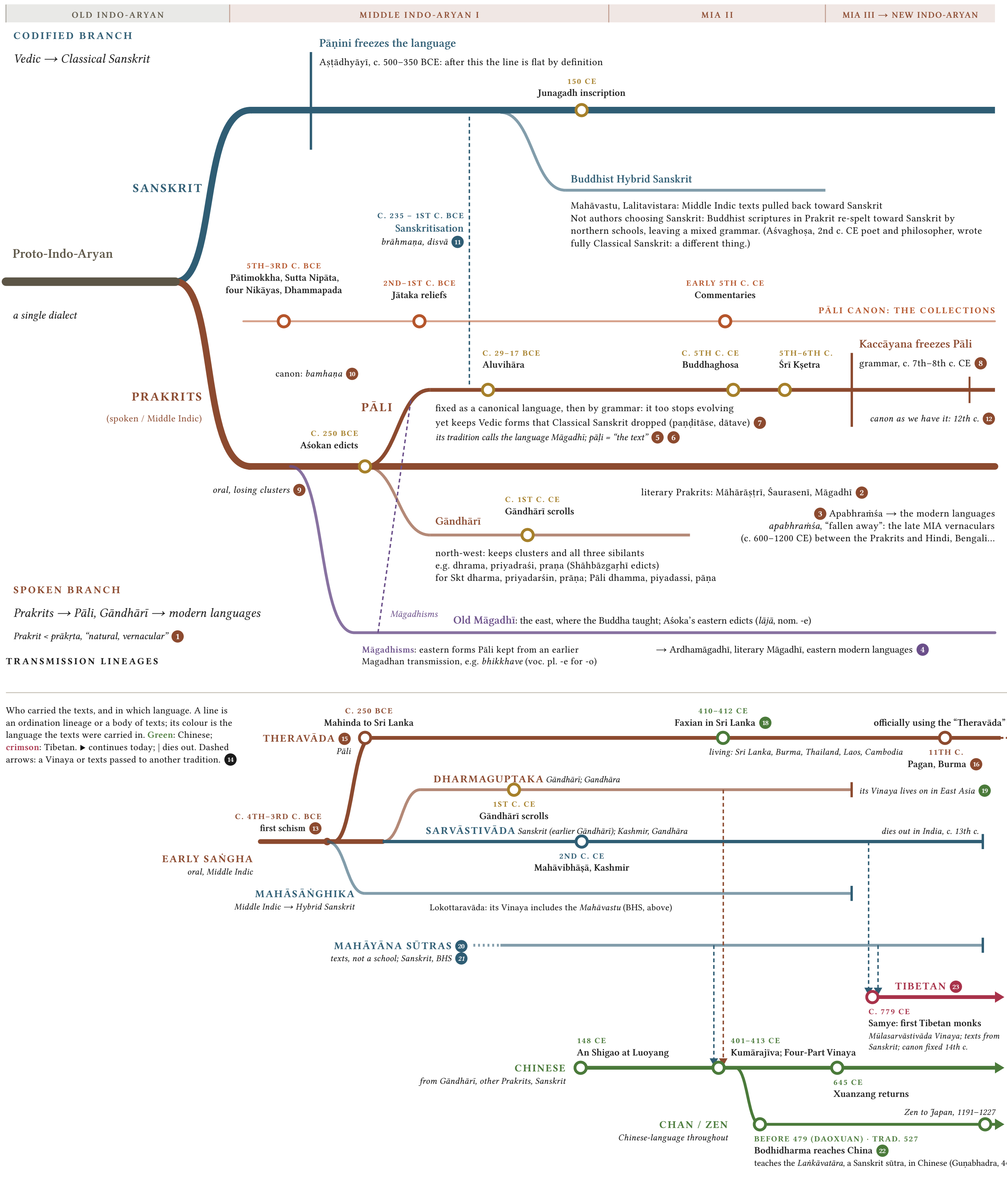
Development of Pāli and Sanskrit from Indo-Aryan Origins



DATED EVIDENCE

C. 250 BCE
Aśokan edicts
The first dated Indic text of any kind, and the anchor everything else hangs on. Nom. sg. -o in the west, -e in the east.
Texts: none quoted, but the Bhabru edict names seven Dhamma texts, usually identified with suttas in the Snp, MN and AN.

C. 29–17 BCE
Aluvihāra
Pāli canon committed to writing (Dīpavaṁsa 20.20–21; Mahāvaṁsa 33.100–101). A tradition, not an artefact.

C. 1ST C. CE
Gāndhārī scrolls
Oldest surviving Buddhist manuscripts: the British Library Kharoṣṭhī birch-bark fragments.
Texts: a Dharmapada, the Rhinoceros Sūtra (= Snp 1.3), Āgama sūtras, avadānas; the Bajaur scrolls add a Prātimokṣa.

150 CE
Junagadh inscription
Rudradāman I, on the Girnār rock at Junagadh, Gujarat (W. India), the same rock as Aśoka's edicts. First long inscription in more or less standard Sanskrit: Sanskrit returns as a public language.
Texts: none Buddhist; a royal eulogy for repairing the Sudarśana lake dam.

C. 5TH C. CE
Buddhaghosa
The commentaries fix Theravāda exegesis, and with it much of how Pāli is read.

MID 5TH–MID 6TH C. CE
Śrī Kṣetra plates
Oldest surviving Pāli text of any kind: twenty gold leaves from the Khin Ba mound at Śrī Kṣetra, the Pyu city near Prome (Pyay), Burma, dug 1926–27. Eight canonical excerpts: praises of the Buddha, dependent origination, factors of awakening.

PĀLI CANON: WHEN THE COLLECTIONS TOOK SHAPE

5TH–4TH C. BCE
Pātimokkha
The monks' rules, by tradition recited by Upāli at the First Council. The same code is in every surviving Vinaya, so its core predates the first schisms.
Finds: a Gāndhārī Prātimokṣa on birch bark in the Bajaur scrolls (NW Pakistan, 2nd c. CE), in a version matching no known school.

5TH–3RD C. BCE
Sutta Nipāta
Discourses in verse. Its Aṭṭhakavagga and Pārāyanavagga are among the oldest Buddhist texts: the canon comments on them in the Niddesa.
Finds: Aśoka's Bhabru edict names a Muni-gāthā, Moneya-sūte and Upatisa-pasine, usually identified with Snp suttas; a Gāndhārī Rhinoceros Sūtra (= Snp 1.3) in the British Library scrolls.

5TH–3RD C. BCE
Four Nikāyas
Dīgha, Majjhima, Saṁyutta, Aṅguttara. Largely fixed before Aśoka; written down in Sri Lanka in the 1st c. BCE. An early core with later additions.
Finds: Bhabru names a Lāghulovāda (cf. MN 61) and Anāgata-bhayāni (cf. AN 5.77–80); Gāndhārī Saṁyukta sūtras in the Senior scrolls (mid-2nd c. CE); Nikāya formulas on the Śrī Kṣetra gold.

5TH–3RD C. BCE
Dhammapada
Verses ascribed to the Buddha, gathered as a collection by about the 3rd c. BCE. Other schools' versions share a core of some 330 verses.
Finds: the Khotan Dharmapada, Gāndhārī birch bark found near Khotan, Xinjiang (1st–2nd c. CE); fragments in the British Library scrolls; Sanskrit Udānavarga leaves from Turfan.

2ND–1ST C. BCE
Jātaka
Only the verses are canonical; some go back to the 5th c. BCE. The prose was fixed in a commentary of about the 5th c. CE.
Finds: the Bhārhut railing (Madhya Pradesh, c. 125–100 BCE) carves jātaka scenes with Brāhmī labels naming them; the Sāñcī gateways show the Vessantara and Chaddanta stories.

EARLY 5TH C. CE
Commentaries
Buddhaghosa renders the old Sinhala commentaries of the Mahāvihāra into Pāli under King Mahānāma (c. 410–434). The Khuddaka commentaries (Dhammapāla and others) are later.
Finds: no early manuscripts; anchored by a document instead: the Chinese translation of the Vinaya commentary (*Shanjian lü piposha*, 488/489 CE).

LINGUA FRANCA AND THE LANGUAGE AT THE FIRST COUNCIL

What language could have served as a lingua franca while the Buddha was travelling among regions? What language could have been used at the First Council?

TL;DR *We should bear in mind three distinctions:*

1. **Literary and vernacular languages.** Pāli has always been literary, a language for teachings and verses, not a conversational language, and only the literary forms survive. The vernacular could have been as close to it as Brazilian to European Portuguese, or more distant, like Italian from Latin. (Literary languages today: the language of laws, which nobody speaks, or the Hebrew of the Bible beside everyday Hebrew.)
2. **The eastern (Magadha) dialect and the western,** both literary. The Buddha taught in the eastern region, and the teachings were later carried on in western India, in its own dialect.
3. **The content of a text and its pronounced form.** Pāli itself was changing over time. Even where the content resists change (repeated formulas, the Pātimokkha) and is carried word for word, the dialect it is pronounced in changes, as the different syllables of Aśoka's edicts and the Gāndhārī scrolls show.

Aśoka's eastern language reached Buddhist sites far from Magadha, at Delhi (Bahapur edict), so it was common enough that administrative instructions were meant to be understood there. But the Kandahar edict is in Greek and Aramaic, so the eastern language clearly had a limit.

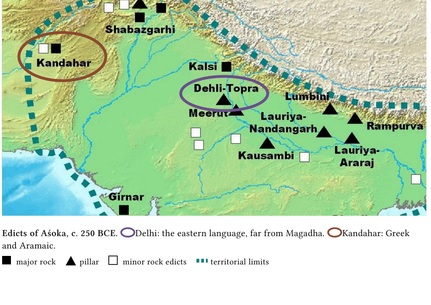
At the First Council they would likely have used the eastern speech of Magadha. The nearest evidence is the eastern language of Aśoka's pillars, about 150 years later: *lājā* for king, not the western *rājā*. The suttas were later taken up in the western regions and recast (hence *rājā*), but kept some eastern forms such as *bhikkhave*. Still later came a light Sanskritisation, when that was in vogue. It put some consonant clusters back, so we get *brāhmaṇa* instead of something like *bamhaṇa*, and also *disvā* and *atraja*, which never had them.

Hence Norman concludes that Pāli in the exact form we have it probably did not yet exist in Aśoka's time, or earlier at the First Council 9 - 12. Its ancestor did, with no consonant clusters and a more eastern pronunciation. To a non-linguist's ear it still sounds much the same, so the distance to the language of the First Council could be like that between strong regional dialects of one language, such as eastern and central German.

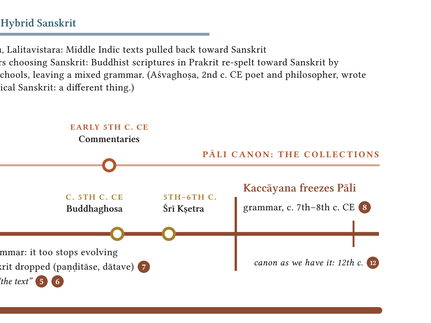
MORE DETAIL

Only the literary languages left dramas, songs or carved artefacts, so claims about a spoken lingua franca cannot be proven. But there is the following.

- **Levman** compares Pāli *sukhumaṁ sallaṁ durubbahaṁ* (Theragāthā) with Ardhamāgadhī, a literary Māgadhī, *suhume salle duruddhare* (Sūyagada), both "a fine dart, hard to extract": the first two words differ regularly, but the third uses a different root.
- **Trade and administration** would make a lingua franca highly likely, but the evidence is later than the Buddha's life.
- **Eastern forms far from Magadha,** meant to be understood there, at least by the officials and monks addressed: the Lumbini pillar, at the Buddha's birthplace, *lājina, hida Budhe jāte*; the Bhabru edict, addressed to the Saṅgha, found in Rajasthan, *lājā Māgadhe*; the Piprahwa relic casket, in Sakyan country (c. 3rd–2nd c. BCE, a relic dedication, not an edict), *salilanidhane, dalanaṁ*, with eastern *l* for *r*.
- **Heard, not only read:** the Separate Edicts at Dhauli and Jaugaḍa, in Kalinga, say that they "must be listened to" on set days.
- **How much further it was understood is less clear.** Norman says the Māgadhī originals were "translated" into the local dialect or language across India, which suggests they were not enough as they stood, and that Girnār may be partly a scribe's attempt to convert the eastern text into what he thought suited the region. At Kandahar the eastern language was not used at all. And those addressed were mostly officials and monks, so the edicts say little about what ordinary listeners understood.
- **The First Council,** if it took place, would likely have used the eastern speech of those present, around Magadha. No sample survives from that time; the nearest evidence is the eastern language of Aśoka's pillars, about 150 years later. On the usual account the suttas were later taken up in the western regions and recast, so the words came out a bit differently: the eastern edicts have *lājā* where Pāli has the western-looking *rājā*, but Pāli still keeps eastern relics such as *bhikkhave* as irregular forms.
- **Norman** calls the canon's language in Aśoka's time "perhaps the lingua franca of the Buddhists of Eastern India", "not very different from the language of the Hathigumpha inscriptions", in which "all consonant clusters had either been assimilated or resolved" (*sarva → sabba; sneha → sineha*). But Pāli as we have it has clusters again, which Norman puts down to light Sanskritisation: some were restored to their older forms (*brāhmaṇa* for something like *bamhaṇa*), some put in wrongly: *disvā* cannot come from *dṛṣṭvā*, nor *atraja* from *ātmaja* (which gives *attaja*), so these clusters were added, not inherited.
- **Not everyone agrees:** Karpik argues that the Buddha taught in Pāli itself.



Mahājanapadas, c. 500 BCE. Magadha, capital Rājagṛha, where the Buddha taught. Gandhāra (top left) is the home of Gāndhārī.



Edicts of Aśoka, c. 250 BCE. Delhi: the eastern language, far from Magadha. Kandahar: Greek and Aramaic.
major rock
pillar
minor rock edicts
territorial limits

Maps from Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0, cropped, rings added: *Mahājanapadas (c. 500 BCE)* by Avantiputra7; *Edicts of Ashoka* by PHGCOM.

Development of Pāli and Sanskrit: Notes

Numbered markers in the diagram refer to these.

1 Prakrits

prākṛta, "natural, ordinary", as against *saṁskṛta*, "refined, put together": the vernacular Middle Indo-Aryan languages that grew out of Old Indo-Aryan speech. In the broad sense every MIA language is a Prakrit, Pāli and Gāndhārī included; in the narrow sense the word means the literary Prakrits of note 2.

2 Literary Prakrits

Prakrits standardised as languages of literature rather than of speech, and codified by grammarians (Vararuci; Hemacandra, 12th c.). In Sanskrit drama kings and brahmins speak Sanskrit, women Śaurasenī, low-status characters Māgadhī; songs are in Māhārāṣṭrī. The Jain canon is in Ardhamāgadhī. All are MIA II: intervocalic stops are lost (Skt *loka* ⟶ Prakrit *loa*, "world").

3 New Indo-Aryan

MIA and NIA in the header are Middle and New Indo-Aryan. NIA is the modern stage, from about 1000 CE: Hindi-Urdu, Bengali, Marathi, Gujarati, Punjabi, Odia, Nepali and many more. They grew out of the regional Apabhraṁśas, not out of Sanskrit or Pāli (Sinhala took its own route from early Middle Indic). Both lent them learned words borrowed whole (*tatsama*) beside words inherited through Prakrit (*tadbhava*): Hindi *karm* beside *kām* < Prakrit *kamma*.

4 Māgadhī: two things with one name

(a) The eastern dialect of Magadha, where the Buddha taught. Aśoka's eastern edicts show it: *lājā* for *rājā*, nom. sg. *-e* for *-o*. Its line runs on into Ardhamāgadhī, the literary Māgadhī Prakrit, and the eastern modern languages (Bengali, Odia, Maithili, Magahi).
(b) The Theravāda name for Pāli itself: the commentaries call the language of the canon Māgadhī, the "root language" (*mūlabhāsā*). Linguistically Pāli looks western (*-o*, *r*), but it passed through eastern hands and keeps Māgadhisms such as *bhikkhave* (dashed purple line).

5 "Pāli" means "the text"

In the commentaries *pāḷi* means "line, row", hence "the canonical text" as against its commentary (*aṭṭhakathā*): *pāḷiyaṁ*, "in the text". So in what the tradition calls Māgadhī, *pāḷi* names the text, not the language. "Pāli" as the language's name comes from *pāḷibhāsā*, "the language of the texts", a later usage.

6 *Sakāya niruttiyā*: whose "own language"?

In the Cūḷavagga (Vin II 139) two brahmin-born brothers, Yameḷa and Utekula, complain that monks of every name, clan and family "corrupt the Buddha's word in their own dialect" (*sakāya niruttiyā buddhavacanaṁ dūsenti*), and propose to put it into *chandas*, the metre of the Veda. The Buddha forbids that, and rules: *anujānāmi, bhikkhave, sakāya niruttiyā buddhavacanaṁ pariyāpuṇituṁ*, "I allow you, monks, to learn the Buddha's word *sakāya niruttiyā*". In the brothers' complaint the phrase plainly means each monk's own speech, and the ruling is most naturally read the same way: each in his own language. Buddhaghosa reads it otherwise: *sakā nirutti nāma sammāsambuddhena vuttappakāro māgadhiko vohāro*, "'own expression' means the Māgadhan usage as the Buddha spoke it", and he glosses *chandaso āropema* as putting it into Sanskrit like the Veda. So the permission to use one's own dialect became a statement that the Buddha's language was Māgadhī (note 4). Which reading is right has been argued for a century; either way the passage rejects recasting the teaching in Sanskrit. Levman adds a caution: of the five Chinese Vinaya parallels, only the Dharmaguptaka is clearly about dialect.

7 Pāli forms older than Sanskrit

Some Pāli forms, mostly in old verse (Sutta Nipāta), are older than Classical Sanskrit: Vedic has them, and Pāṇini's standard dropped them.

Pāli	Vedic	Classical Skt	English
paṇḍitāse	*paṇḍitāsaḥ**	*paṇḍitāḥ*	the wise
nom. pl. masc., a-stem · Snp 4.11			
asmase	*smasi*	*smaḥ*	we are
1st pl. present of √as "be" · Snp 3.9 (kevalino 'smase); RV smasi			
devehi	*devebhiḥ*	*devaiḥ*	by the gods
instr. pl.; verse keeps -ebhi (dantebhi, MN 36)			
dātave	*dātave*	*dātum*	to give
infinitive; Vedic -tave is a dative · Snp 2.7			
dissare	*dadṛśre*	*dṛśyante*	they are seen
3rd pl. middle in -re · AN 5.55; Vedic perfect, RV 1.24.10			

* Vedic ending, as in *devāsaḥ*; the word *paṇḍita* itself is post-Vedic.

devaiḥ has no *bh* for *devehi* (← *-ebhi*) to come from: Pāli descends from a Vedic-shaped ancestor, not from Classical Sanskrit. The spoken branch split off before the freeze.

8 When Pāli froze

Pāli had no single Pāṇini moment; it set in stages. The canon was fixed by recitation, written down at Aluvihāra, read through Buddhaghosa's commentaries (5th c.), then codified by Kaccāyana's grammar, c. 7th–8th c. CE (Pind; tradition ascribes it to the disciple Mahākaccāna). It is modelled chiefly on the Kātantra, not on Pāṇini. Later: Moggallāna (12th c.), Aggavaṁsa's Saddanīti (1154).

NORMAN'S TIMELINE: HOW THE CANON'S LANGUAGE CHANGED

9 Before c. 250 BCE: oral

The texts are handed down orally in Middle Indic dialects, which are losing their inherited consonant clusters. A cluster is *assimilated* when one consonant takes over the other (*sarva* ⟶ *sabba*), *resolved* when an inserted vowel splits it (*sneha* ⟶ *sineha*).

10 c. 250 BCE: Aśoka's time

The canon's language has no clusters left and is more eastern than Pāli: it would have said something like *bamhaṇa*. Norman calls it "perhaps the lingua franca of the Buddhists of Eastern India", "not very different from the language of the Hathigumpha inscriptions". This stage is reconstructed, not attested.

11 c. 235 – 1st c. BCE: Sanskritisation

From about the end of Aśoka's reign to the writing down at Aluvihāra, Sanskrit regains prestige, and redactors restore some clusters (*brāhmaṇa*), sometimes wrongly: *disvā* and *atraja* never had them (dashed blue line).

12 After the writing down

The Sanskritisation is "virtually fixed", and scribes make only minor changes. Norman reports Helmer Smith's view that the canon as we have it reflects the Pāli of the twelfth century.

TRANSMISSION LINEAGES

13 The first schism

The saṅgha's first split, into the Sthaviras ("elders") and the Mahāsāṅghikas ("great community"). Nattier and Prebish (1977) put it 116 years after the Buddha's death: in the 4th or the 3rd c. BCE, depending on the chronology. The sources disagree on the cause. The Pāli account knows only the Second Council at Vesālī, which rejected ten lax Vinaya practices without a split. Other accounts have the Sthaviras expanding the Vinaya and the Mahāsāṅghikas refusing; Sarvāstivāda sources blame Mahādeva's five theses, which ranked the arahant lower. Nattier and Prebish favour the Vinaya account. Every later school traces itself to one side: the Theravāda, Sarvāstivāda and Dharmaguptaka to the Sthaviras.

14 Lineage and language

A Vinaya (ordination) lineage and the language of its texts are separate things. A monk is ordained in a lineage that keeps one school's Vinaya, and may read his texts in another language, or from other schools. The Theravāda is the one surviving lineage that still carries its canon in an Indic language. The other early schools died out in India; two live on only as Vinaya lineages abroad, the Dharmaguptaka in East Asia (note 19) and the Mūlasarvāstivāda in Tibet (note 23).

15 Theravāda in Sri Lanka

"Doctrine of the elders" (Pāli *thera* = Skt *sthavira*): the tradition claims the Sthavira side of the first schism. By the chronicles, Mahinda brought it to Sri Lanka c. 250 BCE. Its canon and commentaries are those of the Mahāvihāra at Anurādhapura, one of three fraternities beside the Abhayagiri and the Jetavana. Parākramabāhu I reformed and unified the saṅgha in 1165.

16 Theravāda in Southeast Asia

Pāli was at Śrī Kṣetra (Burma) by the 5th–6th c. The tradition reached Pagan in the 11th c. (by tradition from the Mon country) and Sukhothai in the 13th. Later it sent ordination back to Sri Lanka when it had lapsed there: the Siyam Nikāya (Upāli from Ayutthaya, 1753), then from Burma the Amarapura (1800–1803) and Rāmañña (1864) Nikāyas. Throughout, Pāli is the shared language of the texts, written in each country's own script, not a spoken language.

17 The name "Theravāda"

Before the modern period "Theravāda" named a lineage of texts and monks; it was not the usual name of the whole tradition. Ānanda Metteyya (Allan Bennett, ordained in Burma) used it that way in 1907. At its founding conference at Kandy in 1950 the World Fellowship of Buddhists, on G. P. Malalasekera's proposal, adopted "Theravāda" in place of "Hīnayāna", and it has been the official label since (Perreira 2012).

18 Faxian

Faxian (337–c. 422) set out from Chang'an in 399 because the Vinaya known in China was incomplete. In North India he found it kept only by word of mouth, with no written copies; at Pāṭaliputra he obtained the Mahāsāṅghika Vinaya. He spent two years in Sri Lanka (c. 410–412) at the Abhayagiri, under Mahānāma, the king in whose reign Buddhaghosa worked, and took home the Mahīśāsaka Vinaya and two Āgamas. He landed in Shandong in 412 and translated the Mahāsāṅghika Vinaya with Buddhabhadra.

19 The Four-Part Vinaya

East Asian monks (China, Korea, Vietnam) are ordained in the Dharmaguptaka Vinaya, the *Four-Part Vinaya* (*Sifen lü*), which Buddhayaśas recited from memory and translated with Zhu Fonian in 410–412. An edict of 709 made it the sole Vinaya in China. The school was Gandhāran: the British Library Gāndhārī scrolls probably come from a Dharmaguptaka monastery library (Salomon). East Asia's texts are Chinese translations from Gāndhārī, other Prakrits and Sanskrit.

20 Mahāyāna: texts, not a school

Mahāyāna was a movement in texts and practice, not an ordination lineage: its monks were ordained in the existing Vinayas. Yijing, in India and Srivijaya 671–695, found Mahāyāna and other monks keeping the same Vinaya, told apart by whether they worshipped bodhisattvas and read Mahāyāna sūtras. In India it faded with Buddhism by c. 1200; it lives on in Chinese and Tibetan translation and in Sanskrit manuscripts kept in Nepal.

21 The language of the Mahāyāna sūtras

The early sūtras were composed in Middle Indic, much of it Gāndhārī, and progressively Sanskritised. A Gāndhārī *Aṣṭasāhasrikā Prajñāpāramitā* (Split collection, radiocarbon c. 1st c. CE; Falk and Karashima 2012) is close to Lokakṣema's Chinese translation (c. 179), the earliest dated Mahāyāna texts. Most sūtras survive in Buddhist Hybrid Sanskrit (the *Lotus Sūtra*); the philosophers, Nāgārjuna (2nd c.), Asaṅga and Vasubandhu (4th–5th c.), wrote Classical Sanskrit.

22 Bodhidharma and Chan

The sources are late and do not agree. The earliest is Yang Xuanzhi's *Record of the Buddhist Monasteries of Luoyang* (547), which mentions a monk from the Western Regions named Bodhidharma, perhaps not the same man. Daoxuan (*Xu gaoseng zhuan*, 645) has him arrive by sea at Nanyue under the Liu Song (420–479), go north to Luoyang, and hand his disciple Huike the *Laṅkāvatāra* in Guṇabhadra's four-fascicle Chinese translation (443). The arrival in 527 and the meeting with Emperor Wu of Liang belong to later Chan histories. Whatever his origin, the tradition he founded is Chinese-language throughout: Chan reads Indian sūtras in Chinese translation and ordains by the Dharmaguptaka Vinaya. It passed to Korea (Seon), Vietnam (Thiền) and Japan (Zen: Eisai 1191, Dōgen 1227), where, as in Tendai after Saichō (822), ordination came to rest on the bodhisattva precepts.

23 Tibetan

Tibetan monks are ordained in the Mūlasarvāstivāda Vinaya, brought by Śāntarakṣita: the first Tibetan monks were ordained at Samye c. 779. The texts were translated from Sanskrit, and the canon, in two parts (Kangyur and Tengyur), was given its final form by Bu ston (1290–1364).